

Transcript 8

So thank you for participating, I really appreciate it.

Of course.

So today, as you could see in the questionnaire already, we're just going to go a bit more in-depth about voice recordings, homesickness and some other variables. So I would like to hear something about your own opinion about them. I'll let you hear a couple of them and see what you think about them. But first of all, how are you feeling today?

I feel well, yeah, pretty even. Yeah, nothing going on today. Normal work day.

Normal day. Yeah. Okay. And where did you grow up?

So where are you originally from and where did you grow up?

So I'm born in a place called Oshawa, Ontario. It's a province in Canada. And I grew up very close to that hospital in a place called Pickering, Ontario. Okay.

So that's in Canada, right?

Yep. Yeah, Canada. Yeah.

And where do you currently live?

The Netherlands, Amsterdam.

Okay.

Ijburg, if it matters.

Yeah, Ijburg.

And what do you consider home?

That's a difficult question. Now I'd consider home to be here. I think after a certain amount of time, it becomes this way. Yeah, I have a long term sort of partner and relationship here. I have a job here. There's certain aspects of my life that are obviously located here. I'm also sort of invested in the community in a way. So I think that changed things a little bit as well. There was a time earlier on when we moved here, though, that maybe I didn't consider that the case. I'm not sure when it

changed. I was thinking about that in anticipation of this. Yeah. Maybe like a year or so. I mean, there's certain amount of things that change around you that indicate home more so, right? You put away all the boxes and yeah, we built a bunch of IKEA furniture. So getting all that done. Also having our own place, which is different, right? We were renting and then had the opportunity to have our own place, which is now the case. So yeah, that changes things a little bit more.

Yeah, exactly. So you say, for example, just the things like unpacking the boxes, getting your own place, would that kind of be like more instead of just being there, like starting to really live there.

That's, that's kind of what I could get. Yeah, there's like a qualitative difference for sure. I'm not sure. Yeah. How to frame it. But yeah, like a feeling that it's, it's normal or natural to think of it first, I guess. Yeah. When people ask about home, it's not a question anymore. You know? Yeah, if you were gonna say, where are you from? That's a bit different. But if they say, where do you live, then that's an easy one. Yeah, I think of home.

Okay, yeah. And now I want to go into kind of a difference between personal and generic voice recordings. And just to clarify a bit with personal voice audio, personal voice recordings, I mean something that's personally connected to you, according to you. So the audio does not need to originate from someone specifically near you or a loved one, but it needs to invoke a personal connection. It can be linguistic, cultural, historical, whichever way you feel it. And generic would kind of just be the opposite of that. So something that doesn't invoke that personal connection. And if you were to think of voice recordings in general that exist or that might exist, which types of voice recordings and what characteristics do you think they would have that would make it more personal to you and why?

Voice recordings that have specific characteristics. I mean, there are probably sound bites and other sort of voices that were recorded. I don't know if this counts. I think it probably does. From when I was a kid, that might have special meaning for me. Maybe it was advertisements or at the beginning of a TV show or something that I have sort of strong memories associated with being a kid and experiencing that. There's things because I'm from the 90s as a kid, there are things like answering machines. Yeah. And like, I can still have memories, for example, of some of my friends, their answering machine because you have that happen so many times to you. It's part of it. Yeah. So the characteristics or qualities of those, some of them are fairly robotic and sort of like they have a lot of noise, actually, just because of the time, I think, in some ways. Like, it's not that they're so super crystal clear or something or I don't even know, like melodious, not so much necessarily. Just it differs a bit. But yeah, especially old TV recordings would probably, they're probably clearer in my memory than they would be actually to imagine now. I'm thinking that right now. Yeah.

And in contrast to those personal voice recordings, what do you think would be the types of voice recordings that would feel more generic to you?

Okay. I mean, there's stuff in ambient sort of everyday life that don't necessarily make me think of anything specific on buses when they announce the stop. That isn't necessarily a personal thing to me. Although I experienced it a lot on the tram or whatever, especially in Ibrook taking the tram. Yeah. Trying to think of other things. Certain amounts of robocalls and like AI bots, when you call something like a banking service or something, and the first customer service step is often those. Yeah. Those don't necessarily feel personal to me. They feel generic, of course. Maybe not, of course. Some people might love that. Trying to think. Other kinds of voice recordings. Yeah, I think that's all I'm thinking of right now. Yeah. I can try to think more if you want.

Yeah, but that's completely fine. So, so far you've filled in one questionnaire. We're now in the interview. I'm going to share another questionnaire with you now in the chat of this meeting. I'm just going to grab the link right now. And what I want you to actually do is just open the questionnaire, keep it on in a tab during the whole interview. It'll contain a couple of new items that correspond to the listening task we're going to perform. And in the listening task, I'm going to let you hear some voice recordings. Okay. So the first question will be... Sorry. Yeah.

I have one question. Sorry. Should I be having the, like you and the survey side by side? Or should I just be having a tab? Does it matter?

It does not really matter. You don't necessarily have to see me. You just have to hear the audio.

Okay.

So as long as you can just fill this in. So it will first ask you for your identifier, your email address or phone number. And then what I'm going to do is I'm going to play five different voice recordings for you. And I want you to rate them based on how generic or how personal they feel to you. So what you're going to see is one item. The first item is going to be someone from a different country talking to you in a language that's not so familiar to you about the weather. And the recording I'm going to let you hear corresponds with that statement and so forth. So the second statement is actually for the second recording. Third is for the third. Once we've done all five, we're going to go back to the interview and we're going to do that hopping back and forth two more times. So you can let me know when you're ready to hear the first recording. I'll let you hear it. Also, please let me know if anything is unclear. You cannot hear the audio, anything like that.

Okay. So I've got my email. So I'm on the first one now. Yeah.

Yeah. So I'm going to let you hear the recording. And then after it's done, you can tell me if I can go to the next recording.

Sure. All right.

So you're ready for the first one?

Yes.

All right.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

Okay. I'm ready for the second one.

Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 8]

[Voice recording audio: recording 15]

[Voice recording audio: recording 22]

Okay.

All right. So you can just, if you answered all five, you can shift back to a different tab or whatever you were having in front of you back then. So based on these five recordings, do you think specific elements of the situations in the recordings affected the matter of personalness and the genericness? And if so, what do you think affected it and in which direction? So what made it more personal or more generic?

I mean, I was interested to learn that kind of the random sort of people doing things, which I would characterize, I guess, as the advertisement or not the advertisement, the national holiday one at the end, wasn't feeling so personal to me. Yeah. And the quality of it didn't really have an effect that I noticed. I mean, I couldn't understand a little bit of it at first, but it was more like, it felt like the radio, which is of sort of time when I was a kid. But yeah, it didn't match my expectations of what I thought coming in. So that was interesting. Yeah.

So that was, if I understand correctly, it was less personal than you expected it to be.

Indeed. Yeah. And then some of the others. So the, I think there's two historical speeches. Yes. Yeah. And that felt more personal for some reason. And I don't know what that is exactly. But yeah, it's a, I think, I don't think I recognize the people speaking, although maybe the current prime minister, maybe, but yeah. That didn't

change it in any direction. They were just two historical speeches to me and in some many ways, but yeah, it was interesting and more personal than I expected.

Yeah. And do you, um, could you explain if you would know, uh, what made the other recordings a little less personal, so more generic?

That's a good question. Um, there was, when I was listening to the Canada Day one, the national holiday, uh, I felt like there was something about, uh, I think that's overly patriotic sometimes to celebrate those things. So there's definitely a uh, cultural judgment I have about, uh, these kinds of big national holidays. Yeah. Um, also advertising. So maybe the, the radio part has an effect there in some ways that feels like, uh, an advertisement. Yes. Or using advertisements to, to make people, uh, sort of buy things. Yes. So you would say, uh, I don't know, uh, is it, is genuity a word? Like how genuine it is.

Oh yeah.

I think that the, the extent to which it's not very genuine sounding to you would also make it a little less personal. It feels more forced. Would you say?

Yeah. No, that could, that could make sense.

Yeah. Especially since it's, I know it's an over air advertisement. Yeah. Um, uh, the, some of the French ones I had trouble with, but there's two, I think French ones, right. Uh, I had trouble, um, not because I didn't understand some of the words I did actually. Um, it's not my first language, but I know some of it. Uh, but I didn't recognize any of that sort of like salesmanship in, in those. It may be there. I just didn't notice. I don't think the description said it had it either. I'm not sure though. Um, yeah. So yeah, I didn't feel badly about those necessarily.

Exactly. Okay. So next up, I kind of want to go to the meaningfulness of a voice recording and it's a kind of a nuanced difference from the personalness. But with this, I mean, if it feels in any way important or relevant to you and if it actually means something to you, which can, for example, be emotionally, but it can also be without emotions, uh, reminding you of something valuable or significant. Um, and of course, a voice recording could be very personal and not that meaningful or it could be not so personal, but it could be meaningful.

Right.

Um, so if you would think about that with that description in mind, what do you think are characteristics of voice recordings that would make them meaningful to you?

Characteristics that make them meaningful to me. So personal could be, if I'm understanding the distinction correctly, could be someone addressing me personally, for example, but that's not necessarily meaningful. It could be a stranger. It could be someone in a different language. It could be, uh, something unrelated to me, the weather from 10 years ago, something like that. Um, I mean, I guess I would have to do, it would have to have contents. I guess it would have audio qualities, but content that was meaningful to me as well. So, um, yeah, what I said originally still applies, I think it's not that, uh, I don't know the, the beginning of Dragon Ball Z from the nineties is super meaningful in a general sense to people. I can't imagine that like the English song or whatever is going to have that sort of meaningfulness for people, but it would for me being a kid then, I guess, or maybe the, the Pokemon song or whatever. Yeah. Yeah. That kind of stuff.

Okay. Yeah.

And the connection to my past, yeah. Things I like or delight even, but yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. So that's a connection to your past.

And can you describe how, how this kind of understanding that you have of the meaningfulness, uh, connects to the difference between voice recordings that you would consider personal versus generic? Do you think there's a correlation between those two?

Okay. Yeah. I mean, uh, it being personal is in a sense more meaningful than it being generic to me, I suppose, even if the content again, isn't, uh, meant to sort of identify me in a, in a specific way, but it's like meant as a personal address, I guess, or something like that. I mean, there's, there's a, when maybe this is not what people usually do, but I imagine when, uh, even something prerecorded is addressing, say the nation or is addressing, um, you as a citizen is addressing you as a person, these are still personal. Uh, and I, uh, anticipate more meaning from them, right. These are being addressed specifically. Yeah. So maybe there's, there's a certain amount of, uh, what do you call that? Uh, confirmation bias. It's like, I expect meaningful because what's happening is, uh, yeah, they're addressing me or expecting me to be listening at least. Yeah. Maybe. Right.

Okay. Yeah. And could you think of, maybe a situation or multiple situations in which the same exact voice recording would feel more meaningful in one situation and less in another?

Um, if it's difficult, I could give some examples of, uh, of different situations if you want. Just one example, maybe.

Yeah. Yes. So for example, being alone or being surrounded by people.

Oh, okay. So if you receive a recording with a bunch of people versus alone, does that change it in terms again, if it's meaningful, they're not personal.

Yes. This is specifically about meaningfulness.

Yeah. Okay. Um, yeah. I mean, there's more, uh, meaning could also be about taking action, which maybe I'm reading too much into it. Right. But if you, for example, are with a group of people and there's a, do you know, the, the test of the national network for like the alarm system? Yeah. I find actually that when I'm with a lot of people, there's, there's, there's way more attention paid to this. It's more meaningful to everyone. It seems like in that moment. Yeah. Whereas if I'm by myself, I just sort of read it carefully and I'm like, okay, it's a test or whatever. But like the, the urgency of it is higher maybe. Um, I don't know why that is. Maybe it's a social sort of contract, right? It's like, oh, it could affect us or something. But yeah, I find myself paying more attention to those sorts of things in groups.

Okay. Yeah.

Yeah. If there's a siren outside and I'm in my house, maybe by myself, I don't really maybe pay the most attention, but if there's a bunch of people in the street and the, the fire truck goes by me and the sound of it carries through or I hear it somewhere, somewhere else, I do pay attention.

Yeah.

There's maybe a difference there. That's not a recorded voice though. So I'm not sure.

But do you think it could translate to a voice recordings? So for example, you're talking about attention. So, um, I'm not gonna give an example of a voice recording, but if you would imagine a voice recording and you receive it and you're alone, do you think you would have a different extent to which you have attention for the voice recording?

Yeah, I can imagine. I mean, the, the testing of the network thing is a voice recording. It's an automated sort of recording. Yeah. And I feel like that does change given the people around or whatever. Um, I'm trying to think of other examples. Maybe if you're in a school, uh, it used to happen when I was a kid more often or in high school, but, um, they announced something over the speaker system and you sort of like, even if it's not about you, you sort of pay attention to it. If it's like something interesting, like someone has to go, he's there, you have to go to the office, they're in trouble or something like this. There's a lot more attention paid to the social sort of aspect. Um, yeah, that's more like a live voice. That sounds like a recording. Uh, I need a good example of a voice recording. Yes. So, but, but if I'm

reading into it, right, uh, then at least being with a group, being in more of a social setting that could affect the attention as to where you pay more attention to the recording.

Yes. So would that then mean that it's more meaningful to you or does that attention not have any effect on the meaningfulness?

Well, I think it depends on the content at that point, right? But it could be more meaningful for me. Uh, at least I'm choosing to prioritize it because of the situation, which is arguably more meaningful also depends on what you think of the meeting. Yeah. So that's a little bit of a difficult gray area. I'm not sure.

Yeah. That's okay.

Because if it's just paying attention to it, but the thing itself isn't that meaningful to me. Yeah. It's different. Yeah. I'm more open to understanding whether it's meaningful or not, or assessing that in the moment and in the group, it seems like, whereas I'm more focused on my own thoughts or whatever I'm doing, I guess when the recorded thing happens alone. So that's something. If you want, we can go on to the next part. If something comes to mind later, then you can also share it at the end.

Okay. Sure. Yeah. Okay.

So, should I...

Yeah. So, uh, I wanted to go back to the questionnaire now. You may have anticipated it already.

Um, I'm there now.

Okay. Yeah. So I'm just going to let you hear the same exact five recordings. And then the next five statements will be about how, um, meaningful they will be to you.

Okay.

So you can just fill them in based on not meaningful at all to very meaningful. Um, right. With the same statements, same recordings.

Okay. All right. I'm ready for the first one.

Yeah. Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 8]

Oh, I'm sorry. I'm getting a call.

No, that's okay. Go for it.

It's not that important. I'm just gonna, uh, let you hear it again.

I'm good actually, but that's okay.

Yeah. No, I can go to the next one if you want.

Yeah, sure. The next one's fine.

Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 15]

[Voice recording audio: recording 22]

All right. So, going back to the interview. According to you, do you think specific elements of these situations affected the meaningfulness? And which of these factors do you think made it much more or much less meaningful?

I think the tone of the last one. Yeah. What kind of like... Yeah, tone, I guess, would be the right term. How serious they were, potentially made it less meaningful. Maybe because I don't need to pay attention I guess, if it's not something sort of serious. It's also, it would be correlated, I guess, with how personal it is. It's not about wishing me anything or speaking to me, not my place in, it is inferred, I guess, is about Canada Day, that there's this collective there, but it's not the same thing as addressing it to someone. Yeah, that was interesting.

Yeah, so you talked about how serious they were. And just to clarify, do you think then that the recording of the speech, which was more serious, that was more meaningful or that was less meaningful?

Potentially more meaningful. I know there's other factors to consider, right? That some of those might actually be also addressing me or at least my place in society, I suppose, as a citizen or whatever historical speeches do that. Yeah, because I think it sort of, also the weather one wasn't super meaningful to me.

Yeah.

Maybe it was deliberate, but it's a city I never lived in also. Local weather.

Yeah.

Not so meaningful.

No, exactly. Okay. Okay. So finally, as the last kind of variable, I want to go and look at the actual supportiveness for coping with homesickness. So with that, I basically mean whether you feel like the voice recording would actually alleviate your feelings of homesickness and to which extent, or maybe the other way around. So it would worsen your homesickness and to what extent.

Okay.

Okay. So once again, please think about voice recordings in general and think about how they might experience, how they might impact your experiences with homesickness. And what do you think are characteristics of voice recordings that would alleviate your homesickness or ones that would maybe worsen your homesickness and why?

Sure. I think there's sort of easy opportunities. If my parents recorded anything and sent it to me, for example, then that might be a homesickness cue or trigger. I can imagine. Yeah. To think of, I mean, I think of here as home now, but to imagine homesickness for that place or the past that way, I guess. Whereas if I were somewhere else, I guess it goes both ways. And my wife were to send a message or a friend here or I guess people that I know here and was away for a while for some reason, that would cause the same thing, I think. Yeah. And I'm not sure the quality of the recording matters then, but maybe it would. I'm not sure what would change. Very personal, I guess, on the spectrum we're talking about, but it would be meaningful because I was away, I suppose. Yeah. That feeling, I think, is less as I've been here longer. Like, for example, for my parents or people from Canada. Yeah. Would be stronger now in the other direction if I were away from friends and family here.

Yeah. Okay. And so can you think of like a situation in which the same exact voice recording would be more supportive for coping with homesickness in one situation and less in a different situation or maybe even worse in a different situation?

Okay. More supportive in one situation. And situation means anything I can think of or just like probably where I am geographically is often there?

It could be many things. Yes. It could be for once again when you're with people or alone. It could be based on your mood. It could be anything you can think of. Yeah.

Okay. Okay. I mean, there are certain times where I feel like people are more susceptible to sort of feeling connected to nostalgic or not nostalgic, but maybe homesickness. Just because they're very tired, right? I can imagine at the end of the day it being more meaningful to hear a voice recording.

Yeah.

In any of the scenarios I described before as compared to the beginning of the day. Yeah. If that makes sense. When I'm sort of tired, I've had a long day or probably when I've been alone all day as well. Hearing people is good. More impactful. Even if it's mundane. Like it's not personal, but it's more meaningful because of how I feel then. Yeah. Yeah. So like a long day of work, probably alone, I can imagine the same voice recording would have a different effect as compared to even a few hours earlier. Yes.

Yes. So do you think that effect would go in a specific direction for the supportiveness? For example, if you imagine yourself coming home from a long day and you're indeed alone and you listen to a recording, would that be more supportive, do you think, for coping with homesickness or less?

I think it depends on who and what is being said a little bit, of course. But in general terms, yeah, I think hearing someone from here, I guess, like my wife or friends, would make me feel sort of less homesick.

Yeah.

And then the opposite would be true depending on which place I'm in. Hearing my parents or somebody from Canada would make me feel more.

Yeah. For example, so what you're saying is hearing a voice recording from someone that's actually in your proximity more, that would be good for alleviation of homesickness. And then someone that's physically more distant from you right now, that would probably, at least you think so, would worsen it?

Yeah. I guess that's fair. Because there's no way to be with people that are far away more directly. It's not that you can't speak to them or whatever, obviously. But, yeah.

Okay. Yeah. So now for the final time, I want to go back to the questionnaire. Just let you hear the same recordings again. And you can fill them in based on how supportive you think they are. So ranging from not supportive at all to very supportive.

Okay. I'm on the page now. So go ahead. The first one.

All right.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 8]

Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 15]

[Voice recording audio: recording 22]

All right. So, based on those recordings, what do you think are the characteristics that made it either more supportive or less supportive for coping with homesickness?

Yeah. Um, I mean, part of it is you, you put the concepts in my brain and they're sort of tumbling around a little bit. But none of those are very personal to me. Um, I didn't have what I thought were strong reactions in any direction for any of those, sharing that component. And the sort of conversation before that we were having was more about, yeah, what would it be like to have someone quite personal to me leave a voice recording?

Yeah.

What that would feel like at the end of a long day or when I'm alone, et cetera. So I think, yeah, it wasn't very affecting at all. Yeah. In this case, I didn't have strong feelings. Yeah.

Yeah. Okay. Um, so what I would like you to do kind of as a final, uh, thing in the interview is I would like you to imagine a voice recording of a loved one or someone very close to you, a good friend, maybe a family member, and they're talking to you personally. Um, so talking to you about something personal, um, and how meaningful do you, do you think that such a recording would be for you and why? And also how supportive for coping with homesickness do you think it would be and why?

Okay. Um, the supportiveness is interesting because I started thinking about homesickness as two places at once now. Right? Um, it was like, depending on where they were, uh, yeah, I think it's a bit what you just went into, um, about the different home locations, uh, being from one end to the other end, um, would be kind of alleviating for homesickness and vice versa for the other one. Yeah. And that seems about right. Um, there are people, um, like my wife and, uh, some friends, I think that might transcend that. That would make me miss them sort of no matter where I was. Um, but that's not quite the same as missing home. Uh, yeah, it's about the same. It could be the same depending on the person actually. Yeah. Uh, my, my feelings about what home is, is tied up with other people for sure. So that's, that's difficult. Uh, if I were to imagine the opposite, like what would be home if there were no people that lived here at all and vice versa, um, it wouldn't matter so much. I don't think, the buildings. So yeah. I find that, I find that difficult. So if one of the people that live in these homes, right. That I could be homesick for in either direction. Um,

where the people are recording, then that would make a big difference. I think it would.

Yeah. Yeah. Okay. And is there anything that we haven't covered about voice recordings, homesickness, any of the variables we talked about that you still feel is important to share in this context?

Hmm. Supportiveness is an interesting idea. Hmm. Because in a way, I think you could, you could argue, I mean, too much in my head, but you could argue that, uh, if something makes you feel homesick. Yeah. Then it's a kind of, uh, indication of emotional connection as well. Uh, it's not that it's, uh, indicative of a lack of emotional connection. That's for sure. It's because you have a tie or something pulling you that's strong to that place. Or that you used to call home.

Yes. It enables you to have the ability to feel that emotion at least?

Yeah. So supporting, uh, sort of strong emotional connection while, uh, also supporting a feeling of homesickness. It's both at once, right? It's like, uh, two sides of the same thing. So, um, not sure. Uh, that's all I was thinking as we've been talking. So I think that's interesting.

Yeah. Yeah. That's great. And if you're willing to share, and also if you are able to think of something like this, if you could choose or think of one kind of voice recording or maybe one specific voice recording that would come to mind, um, that you feel would be very effective for coping with homesickness in your case. Um, what would that be for you? What would, um, the type of voice recording be?

Hmm. It would be something to pull me out of the moment, right? Because I think homesickness is, well, I could be wrong, but it would be most often for me a moment of quiet reflection, right? Maybe at the end of the day, like I was saying before. Um, so it'd be someone pulling me into a, uh, sort of very proximate moment that's sort of happy and, um, potentially not happy, but also, um just very, uh, urgent here. Yeah. So immediately my brain would probably go to that place, whatever that is. Um, someone inviting me to go somewhere or, you know, suggesting I do something or just needing my attention immediately.

Yeah.

That would be one sort of way to probably jolt my brain out of it.

All right. Yeah. That, that was it. Is there anything else that you would like to add?

It's like a more complicated feeling than I thought it would be. Yeah. It's interesting.

Yeah. Yeah. I think, uh, I think the same. It brings me a lot of new information that seems very valuable to me as well.

Yeah. That's good. Yeah. Of course. Yeah. Uh, I know what your email is and stuff. So if I ever want to find out what happened with all the paper, then I'll find out.

Yeah. All right. That's great. Thank you so much.